FREE TOOLKIT · VERSION 1.0 · NOVEMBER 2026

AI Readiness Toolkit

A 4-week program to help small teams use AI safely, confidently and well. Includes a skills check, a use-case picker, four session guides, a safe-use policy template and a results tracker.

Description
Explaining a task clearly to AI

Delegation
Deciding what AI should and shouldn't do

Discernment
Judging whether AI output is right

Diligence
Using AI safely and responsibly

AI is only as safe as the people who build it and use it.

Created by Nuhamin H. Tesfay · Based on the Cybersecurity & AI Capital Model (CCM), published in the Proceedings of the Southeastern INFORMS Conference 2026. The four abilities follow the AI Fluency framework by Rick Dakan and Joseph Feller.

START HERE

How to use this toolkit

This toolkit helps a small business or nonprofit with 5 to 50 staff go from “we have AI tools” to “our team uses them safely and well” in four weeks. No AI or IT specialist is needed. One person, the **facilitator**, runs the program.

The four abilities

Ability	What it means	Sign it’s missing
DESCRIPTION	Explaining a task to AI with enough context to get a useful answer	“AI never gives me what I want”
DELEGATION	Deciding which tasks, or which steps, AI should do and which stay with a person	AI used for everything, or for nothing
DISCERNMENT	Checking AI output for errors, invented facts and bias	AI answers copied without review
DILIGENCE	Using AI safely, legally and transparently	Customer or private data pasted into free tools

The 4-week plan

When	What happens	Use
Week 0	Every staff member takes the readiness check (15 minutes). The facilitator picks 2–3 tasks where AI can help most.	Worksheets 1 and 2
Week 1	Session 1: Diligence. Share the safe-use rules before anyone uses AI for work.	Session guide 1, Template
Week 2	Session 2: Description. Writing clear requests.	Session guide 2
Week 3	Session 3: Delegation. Breaking work into steps.	Session guide 3
Week 4	Session 4: Discernment. Catching AI mistakes. Retake the readiness check and compare.	Session guide 4, Worksheet 3

Why safe use comes first: staff start using AI on day one, so the rules must come before the skills.

What you need

- One 60-minute session per week, in person or on a video call
- An AI tool the organization already has or approves (for example Microsoft Copilot, ChatGPT, Gemini or Claude)
- A shared document as a “prompt library,” where staff save requests that worked

Prefer to take the readiness check online? Use the free AI Fluency Check, which scores you instantly and gives you a learning plan.

WORKSHEET 1 · WEEK 0 AND WEEK 4

AI readiness check

Rate each statement from **1** (not at all true) to **5** (very true). Takes about 15 minutes. Repeat in Week 4.

Name or initials (optional): _____ Date: _____

#	Ability	Statement	1	2	3	4	5
1	DESCRIPTION	I can explain a task to an AI tool clearly enough to get a useful first answer.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2	DESCRIPTION	I give AI context, such as the audience and the format I need.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3	DESCRIPTION	When the answer is off, I know how to rephrase my request.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4	DELEGATION	I know which of my weekly tasks AI could speed up.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5	DELEGATION	I know which tasks should not be given to AI.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6	DELEGATION	I can break a large task into steps AI can help with.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7	DISCERNMENT	I check AI answers for errors before I use them.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8	DISCERNMENT	I can spot when AI has made up a fact, name or source.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
9	DISCERNMENT	I know when an AI answer needs a second opinion from a person.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10	DILIGENCE	I know what information I must never put into an AI tool.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
11	DILIGENCE	I tell people when AI helped create something I share.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
12	DILIGENCE	I know who to ask if I'm unsure whether an AI use is allowed.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Ability	Statements	My score (3–15)
Description	1–3	
Delegation	4–6	
Discernment	7–9	
Diligence	10–12	

Score	Level	What it means
3–7	Starting	Needs the full session
8–11	Developing	Needs practice and feedback
12–15	Confident	Can coach a colleague

Facilitator: the team's lowest-scoring ability tells you where to spend the most time. Staff who score Confident on Diligence can be "AI champions" who answer colleagues' questions.

WORKSHEET 2 · WEEK 0

Pick your first 2–3 use cases

Start with tasks that pass all four tests. Low-risk, frequent tasks build confidence fast.

Test	Question to ask
Frequent	Is it done at least weekly?
Time-consuming	Does it take 30 minutes or more each time?
Low-risk	Would a mistake be caught before it reaches a customer?
No sensitive data	Can it be done without customer, health or payment details?

Ideas by role

Role	Good first use case	Keep with a person
Owner / manager	Drafting emails, meeting summaries, job postings	Hiring and firing decisions
Sales / marketing	Social media drafts, product descriptions, campaign ideas	Final pricing and contract terms
Customer service	Reply templates, FAQ drafts	Complaints, refunds, sensitive cases
Operations	Checklists, procedures, schedules	Safety and compliance sign-off
Finance / admin	Summarizing reports, formatting spreadsheets	Tax filings, payroll, payments
Nonprofit programs	Grant outlines, newsletters, translation drafts	Final budgets, beneficiary data

Our chosen use cases

Task	Owner	Minutes it takes today	Passes all 4 tests?
			☐
			☐
			☐

The “minutes it takes today” column is your baseline for Worksheet 3.

Session 1: Diligence

GOAL Staff can use AI without exposing private data.

0–10 min	Why safe use comes first. Share one real example of an AI data leak or mistake in the news.
10–30 min	Walk through the Safe-Use Policy together. Fill in the approved tools and contact person.
30–50 min	**Practice:** sort 10 sample requests into “OK for AI” and “Not OK.” Discuss the tricky ones.
50–60 min	Everyone signs or acknowledges the policy. Questions.

Facilitator tip: make reporting mistakes safe. People who fear blame hide problems.

Session 2: Description

GOAL Staff get a useful first draft in one or two tries.

0–15 min	The four parts of a good request: **task, context, audience, format**. Show a weak and a strong request side by side.
15–25 min	How to fix a weak answer: say what was wrong (“too long,” “too formal”) instead of starting over.
25–50 min	**Practice:** each person rewrites one of their chosen use cases as a four-part request and compares results.
50–60 min	Add the best requests to the shared prompt library.

Weak: “Summarize this.”
Strong: “Summarize this report in 5 bullet points for our board, who aren’t technical. Flag any decisions they need to make.”

Session 3: Delegation

GOAL Staff can decide what to hand to AI and what to keep.

0–15 min	What AI does well (drafting, summarizing, reformatting) and what stays with people (decisions about people, money, legal and safety matters).
15–45 min	**Practice:** map one chosen use case into steps. Mark each step “AI drafts,” “Person does,” or “Person checks.”
45–60 min	Share maps. Agree on one new workflow to try this week.

Session 4: Discernment

GOAL Staff catch AI mistakes before they spread.

0–15 min	How AI gets things wrong: invented facts and sources, outdated information, confident tone, bias.
15–40 min	**Practice:** find the errors in three prepared AI answers, each with one planted mistake.
40–50 min	Checking habits: open every source, double-check numbers and names, ask a person when stakes are high.
50–60 min	Everyone retakes the readiness check (Worksheet 1).

Preparing the practice answers: ask an AI tool a question you know the answer to, then edit in one wrong number, one fake source or one wrong name. Keep an answer key.

TEMPLATE · SHARE IN WEEK 1

AI Safe-Use Policy

Organization: _____ Effective date: _____

Approved tools

Only these AI tools may be used for work: _____

Never put into an AI tool

- Customer or client names, addresses, phone numbers or emails
- Payment, bank or credit card details
- Health or medical information
- Passwords, login details or security settings
- Employee records, salaries or performance reviews
- Contracts or documents marked confidential

Always

- Check facts, numbers and names before using an AI answer.
- Have a person review anything sent to customers, funders or the public.
- Remove names and details before pasting text in (“a customer” instead of a name).
- Be open about AI’s role in important work when asked.

AI never makes the final decision on

Hiring, pay, pricing, refunds, legal or safety matters.

Questions or mistakes

Contact: _____

Reporting a mistake early is always the right call and will not be punished.

Staff acknowledgment: _____ Date: _____

These rules follow common practice from the NIST AI Risk Management Framework, scaled down for a small team. They are not legal advice. Organizations that handle health or payment data should also check the rules that apply to their sector.

WORKSHEET 3 · WEEK 0 AND WEEK 4

Results tracker

Record four numbers before Week 1 and after Week 4.

Measure	How to collect it	Week 0	Week 4	Change
Average readiness score per ability (3–15)	Worksheet 1			
Minutes per chosen task	Time each use case once			
Staff using AI weekly (%)	One-question survey			
Safe-use mistakes reported	Reports to the contact person			

Team scores by ability

Ability	Week 0 average	Week 4 average	Notes
Description			
Delegation			
Discernment			
Diligence			

What success looks like after 4 weeks

- Most staff score at least “Developing” (8 or higher) on every ability.
- Each chosen task takes noticeably less time, with quality checked by its owner.
- No sensitive data has gone into an AI tool.

Close the program with a one-page summary for leadership: what changed, what you learned, and which tasks to add next.

KEEP LEARNING

Free resources

Resource	Good for
AI Fluency: Framework & Foundations (Anthropic Academy)	The four abilities in depth; free certificate
Google AI Essentials (Grow with Google)	Everyday AI skills at work
Microsoft Learn: AI and Copilot training paths	Teams that use Microsoft 365 and Copilot
IBM SkillsBuild	AI basics and responsible AI
Elements of AI (University of Helsinki)	How AI works, for non-technical learners
NIST AI Risk Management Framework	Deeper guidance on managing AI risk

About this toolkit

The AI Readiness Toolkit was created by **Nuhamin H. Tesfay**, an AI governance and cybersecurity researcher. It turns research on AI fluency, the Cybersecurity & AI Capital Model (CCM), published in the Proceedings of the Southeastern INFORMS Conference 2026, into a practical program for small teams. The four abilities follow the AI Fluency framework developed by Rick Dakan and Joseph Feller.

You are free to use and share this toolkit with credit. It is a learning resource, not legal or compliance advice.

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